

Appendix 2 Note of Concern Record

Stage 1 2 **3** (Circle as Appropriate)

Student's Name: Cian Mac Liatháin
ID Number: 11476078
Address: 56 Earls court Street, Belfast, BT127AS
Telephone/Contact Details: Mobile Phone: 0894846527
Email: cmacliathain01@qub.ac.uk / c.macliathain2@universityofgalway.ie
Date of Birth: 10 February 1993
Gender: Male

Concern raised by: Professor Ciara Meehan, Dean of Students

Brief outline of concern:

Brief factual description of the concern. Specific examples/observations are particularly helpful.

On 19 September 2024, Interim President Professor Peter McHugh, having consulted as appropriate, invoked an immediate temporary suspension of Cian Mac Liatháin under Section 9 and Appendix 5 of QA269 Support for Students in Crisis policy. Cian was notified of the suspension on 20 September, and in line with Appendix 5 of QA269, the Dean of Students then invoked stage three of the policy, bypassing stages one and two.

Brief summary

This student has a chronic mental health condition and a history of presenting with acute episodes of deterioration in his mental health. This has been cyclical to date with periods of lucidity and engagement with services, but then at times can quickly deteriorate due to non-compliance with treatment and specialist support.

This student has been involuntarily admitted to the inpatient mental health unit at University Hospital Galway on two occasions in the past 16 months - once with the assistance from Gardai in May 2023, when he presented in a state of agitation and distress on campus, and more recently earlier this year via an application made by a family member.

Recent extensive and repeated emails to various staff in the University, particularly certain colleagues in the School of Education, raised serious concerns about Cian's behaviour and wellbeing. When this latest set of correspondence began, around 4 September, Cian was then a graduate of the University, rather than a current student. As a result, we were not initially able to provide help and support under QA269. However, he was registered at Queen's University, Belfast, and based on emails that members of staff at our University were copied into, we could see that efforts there were being made to help him. A precautionary suspension was invoked by Queen's. Our position changed when Cian subsequently registered for the Ard-Diplóma sa Ghaeilge Fheidhmeach for the 2024/25 academic year; we became aware of his status on 17 September.

In summary,

- A high volume of emails was sent over a relatively short period of time, from around 4 September. One colleague reported receiving 94 emails between 10th and 18th September. In an email to the Dean of Students' office, the staff member wrote, 'I would appreciate if this harassment could be stopped'. The staff member has also received

support from the Head of Counselling; they have found the content of the emails distressing, and they have also been distressed about Cian being in distress.

- The content of emails was, at times, incoherent and potentially disturbing.
- University of Galway staff members have been named in some of the emails, and their actions have been inaccurately represented.
- The emails also include some references to historical abuse; the University is mandated to report any such disclosures to Tusla.

The activity summarised above was not isolated, but rather it is part of a broader and repeated pattern of behaviour when Cian is experiencing deterioration of his mental health.

Supporting documentation includes sample emails, the Risk Assessment Grid from Appendix One of QA269 (completed by Dr Eoin MacDonncha, Head of the Health Unit), and a more detailed risk assessment, compiled by Dr MacDonncha and Kelly Monaghan, Senior Social Worker in Student Services. Please note: these assessments are based on the latest emails sent by Cian.

Overview of attached emails:

- **5 Sept – John Hannon:** Email re: John Hannon (Director of Student Services) following on from email exchange between Cian and John on 24 April 2023 about support available. Email of 5 September references right to mental health damages and requests a public apology.
- **5 Sept – Innocence:** Additional email sent on 5 September by Cian, asking for his innocence to be noted. The content is rambling and disjointed.
- **5 Sept – Professor Colm Mac Donald:** A further email on this date, referencing a conflict of interest and requesting damages.
- **8 Sept - Tusla:** Copied in on an email sent by Cian to Tusla that was forwarding an email from 26 April 2023. Includes reference to child abuse.
- **8 Sept – Minister of State:** Forwarded an email that had been sent to Minister of State Darragh Butler on the same day; the email to the Minister was asking for a follow up on an email sent on 21 May 2024 in which Cian had outlined diagnosis and treatment, and alleged medical abuse by ‘Dr MacDonald’.
- **8 Sept – Mandated Report:** Forwarded an email that had been sent to Andrew Hunter (School of Nursing and Midwifery) asking if he was mandated to ‘report my accusation of Colm McDonalds intentional medical malpractice abuse of me’.
- **8 Sept – Legal Aid:** Copied in on email forwarded to the Gardaí that had originally been sent to Galway Law Centre on 2 June 2023 requesting free legal aid. Outlines relationship with family.
- **8 Sept – Inpatient Psychiatrist:** Email sent directly to Dean of Students. Asks why Colm McDonald is allowed to be Cian’s inpatient psychiatrist due to a perceived conflict of interest. References further information Cian posted on his social media. Also alleges that his father is a ‘paedophile’ and references an alleged example.
- **8 Sept – Dáil Debates:** Copied in on email to Prof MacDonald, calling on him to ‘recuse yourself’ from the University. The email contains a thread to Leo Varadkar, the Ceann Comhairle of the Dáil and Tusla alleging abuse (and complaining in the email subject line that Dáil debates were being controlled).
- **9 Sept – QUB Disability:** Copied in on email thread with Queen’s Disability. The tone of the emails is abusive, and includes the line ‘who the fuck is Will Plunket?’.
- **10 Sept – False Advertising / Refund:** Copied in on email to Queen’s SU. A series of rambling emails. Accuses false advertising and requests refund. (Copied in on multiple other emails of a similar nature also sent on 10 September; not included due to the similarity of the example provided).

- **10 Sept – Hingy, Thirsty, Hurt:** Copied in on email to Robin Hickey (Queen's), describing himself as 'having an extreme emergency situation', and as being 'Hingry [sic], Thirsty, Hurt'.
- **11 Sept – Support Fund:** Copied in on email to QUB Support Fund. References having got out of a 'life threatening situation' and asks 'When will I be assigned an emotional support animal, and educational technology to help me desensitise my academic year from your abuse of me hidden behind plausible deniability?' Email includes a threat that shows that QUB contacted Cian the same day to explain 'Student Wellbeing will lead as your central point'. This was further clarified in an email on 12 September.
- **11 Sept – Damages:** Copied in on email to QUB Appeals. Includes line, 'You are obliged to pay damages to me for the pain caused to me, the worry caused to my family and the slander of my family name(s)'. Copied in on other emails on 11 September alleging that Queen's is educationally biased; not included due to similarity of example provided.
- **12 Sept – Demanding Reply:** Copied in on emails to colleagues in Galway, claiming they are legally required to reply. Please note: during Cian's last period of decline in mental health, these colleagues received a large quantity of emails, similar in nature.
- **12 Sept – QUB expression of concern:** Copied in on email sent to Maeve McCaldin (DSS, University of Galway) that was forwarding angry response to email of concern from Queens.
- **12 Sept – Cornelia Connolly:** Copied in on confused email addressed to Prof Cornelia Connolly (Education, University of Galway) but actually sent to Maeve McCaldin. Includes an email thread sent to QUB Support Fund.
- **13 Sept – QUB Risk Assessment:** Copied in on email sent to Maeve McCaldin (Galway) that included a Risk Assessment conducted by Queen's. Cian's email read 'I did NOTHING wrong. Their description of events is incorrect and the assumption of my guilt throughout this document is astounding. Wish me luck... Egwene the Novice has been summoned by the Mistress of Novices for penance, and must bend the knee'. The letter advised, 'The decision of the Risk Assessment Panel was that in light of your behaviour a precautionary suspension by imposed with immediate effect'. It also explained, 'The Panel was also concerned at the level of disruption that your behaviour has caused, and agreed that the potential risk to yourself, other students, staff, the wider community, as well as the reputational risk to the University, was such that an immediate precautionary suspension was warranted'. I have included a copy of the letter in the supporting evidence. Over the next number of days, the Dean of Students was copied in on a series of angry and confused emails sent to Queen's. These have not been included due to the similarity in nature, but can be supplied if needed.
- **16 Sept – Cornelia Connolly 2:** Copied into email to Cornelia Connolly (University of Galway) that opens with 'This is the last time I will email you directly, biaaaaaatch. You have insulted severely'. Includes screenshot that appears to be from social media referencing Colm MacDonald (referred to as a 'c***') in the email to Cornelia. Multiple emails were subsequently sent to Prof Connolly over the course of the 16th. Rather than including all of them, an additional example is included as '**16 Sept - Cornelia Connolly 3**'. Please note, that in addition to sending these emails directly to Prof Connolly, multiple people were also copied into them.
- **(17 – 18 September:** copied in on emails to various parts of QUB about suspension and cancellation of personal training sessions at QUB gym. These have not been included as they are similar in tone to others, but can be made available).
- **18 Sept – 94 emails received:** Email from a University of Galway colleague (identity redacted) alerting Dean of Students to volume of emails received. 'I would appreciate if this harassment could be stopped'.
- **19 Sept – Black Eye:** BCCd into an email to Student Wellbeing at Queen's, which included a photo of Cian with a black eye.

- **20 Sept – Notice of Suspension and Support:** Email from Dean of Students to Cian notifying him of temporary suspension and support under QA269.
- **20 Sept – Response:** Email response from Cian to notification of temporary suspension and support.
- **21 Sept – Official Complaint:** Copied in on official complaint sent to Medical Council of Ireland about Colm MacDonald. A copy of the complaint form is also included.

At the time of submission (24 September) no further emails have been received by the Dean of Students.

Comments/Observations of other Academic/Admin/Support Staff:

Record observations, with specific examples where available, made by staff/others, other than the person who first reported concern. This can include observations/comments made by appropriate professional support services/academic mentors/welfare staff.

Please find attached the Risk Assessment Grid from Appendix One of QA269 (completed by Dr Eoin MacDonncha, Head of the Health Unit), and a more detailed risk assessment, compiled by Dr MacDonncha and Kelly Monaghan, Senior Social Worker in Student Services.

Student's Comments/Observations:

The student should be invited to record their comments/observations on the concerns and the support plan/follow-up arrangements.

Please find attached Cian's email response to the notice of temporary suspension and support (labelled 20 Sept – Response to Notice).

Agreed Action Plan:

This may include details of any supports recommended/arranged, as well as agreed outcomes that are desirable and limits of acceptable interactions/behaviour, where appropriate.

N/A.

As stage 3 was invoked in line with Appendix 5 of QA269, stages one and two, where an action plan would ordinarily be agreed, was bypassed.

Important Note: (If Leave of Absence or Withdrawal is being considered)

It is important both the student and the University to consider all possible financial implications of a leave of absence or withdrawal from the degree programme. There may be financial implications for student registration/tuition fees or grant if or when a student returns to third level at a later date. Further detailed advice on fees can be obtained from the Fees Office, University of Galway. The Dean of Students at her/his discretion shall have the authority to grant a fee waiver if deemed necessary considering the circumstances of the case.

Addendum to Note of Concern

3 October 2024

In the original Note of Concern, dated 24 September, concludes that no further emails had been received at the time of submission by the Dean of Students. This addendum has become necessary as Cian has not complied with the terms of his suspension.

Throughout your suspension, all queries must be directed to deanofstudents@universityofgalway.ie only. Other emails should not be copied into the correspondence. Should this not be respected, the University will have to take measures to temporarily restrict your email access. Reasonable response times apply.

He continues to copy staff into emails sent to the Dean of Students, and he has also emailed staff directly. One colleague reported receiving 17 emails over the weekend of 27 September, with an additional five sent on Monday 30 September. Another colleague received 24 emails from the morning of 27 September and over the course of the weekend.

Cian has also repeatedly stated that his set of questions about his suspension have not been answered by the Dean of Students. (On 30 September he wrote, 'I emailed you as requested on the 20th of September with clarifying questions. I emailed you again on Thursday 26th of September, with clarifying questions. Feigned ignorance of obligation is a crime called gaslighting').

- The first email, with responses, was sent to Cian's University of Galway address on 25 September.
- After Cian explained that he was unable to access his University of Galway account, the email was resent to his QUB on 26 September.
- Cian's email of 30 September included a thread that showed he was replying to the email of 26 September email.
- Wrote to Cian on 1 October, confirming that both requests had received responses, and included PDFs of the replies.
 - His response included, 'You did NOT reply to the content of my latest emails to you. I don't open or read random PDFs when the basis for them sending to me is false, why would I?'

Cian seems to be experiencing difficulty processing or retaining information.

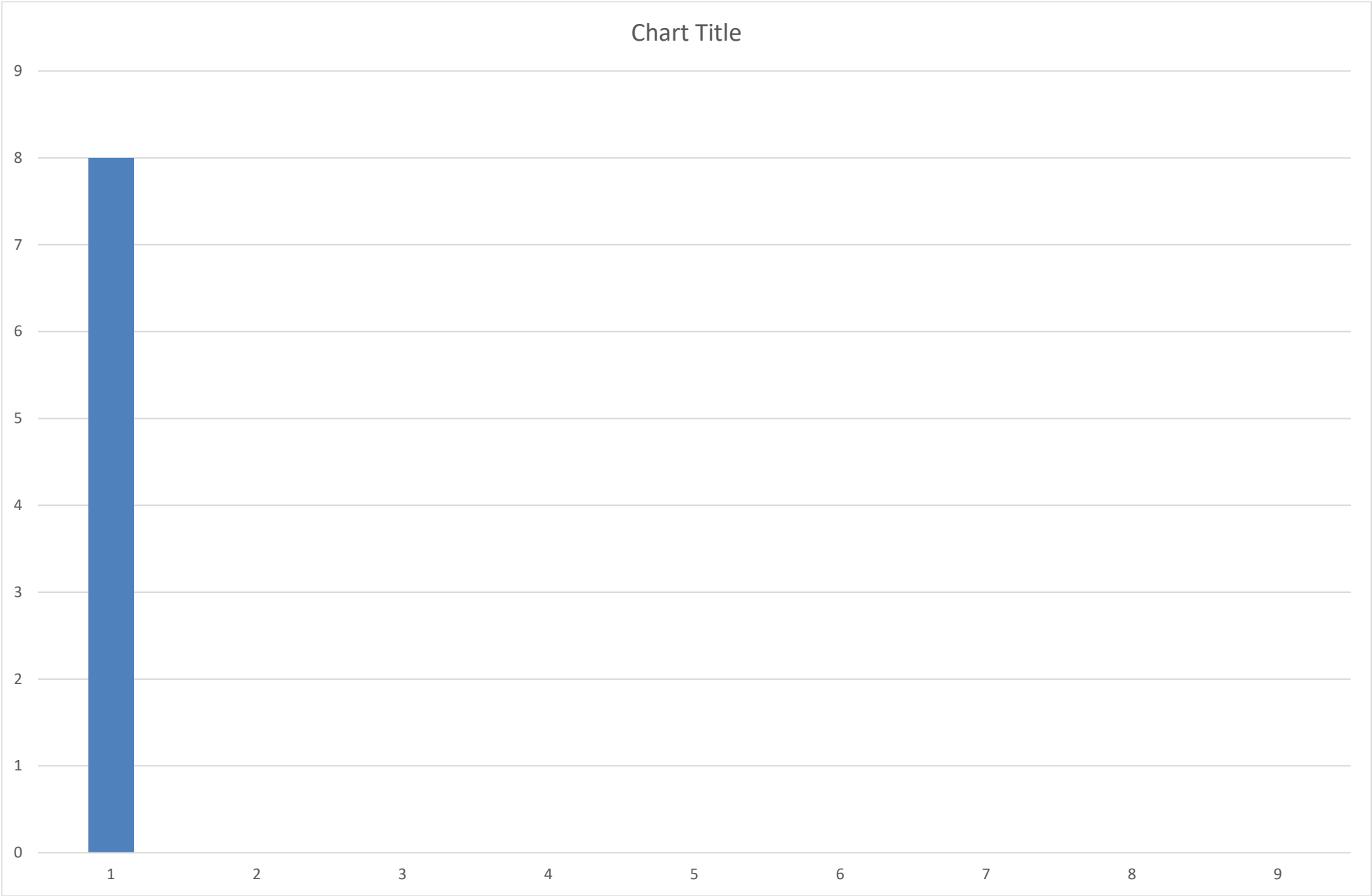
Overview of additional emails submitted as supporting documentation:

25 September 2024: First email to Cian with responses to his questions. Email thread includes Cian's requests.

26 September 2024: Email thread in which Cian claims that he has not received a response to his queries. Thread includes the second email sent to him with responses to his questions.

30 September 2024: Email thread in which Cian again claims that he has not received responses. Thread includes the email with information that had been sent to him.

1 October 2024: Email thread in which Cian refuses to accept that emails had been sent to him and refusing to open PDF copies of emails. Thread includes email from DoS office earlier that day, explaining when emails had been sent and attaching copies of them as PDFs for ease of access.



STUDENT RISK ASSESSMENT

School: Ard-Dioplóma sa Ghaeilge Fheidhlim	Student: Cian Mac Liathain	Date of Risk Assessment: 19.09.2024	Carried out by: Social Worker/ Head of SHU/Dean of Students/ Head of counsel
		Date of Review:	

Activity/basic information re: This student has a chronic mental health condition and a history of presenting with acute episodes of deterioration in his mental health. This has been cyclical to date, with periods of lucidity and engagement with services, but then at times can quickly deteriorate due to non-compliance with treatment and specialist support. This student has been involuntarily admitted to the inpatient mental health unit at University Hospital Galway on two occasions in the past 16 months - once with the assistance from Gardai in May 2023, when he presented in a state of agitation and distress on campus, and more recently earlier this year via an application made by a family member. Staff from Queens University Belfast report that last week, Cian was detained by PSNI and brought to hospital in Belfast, where he was admitted for two days. Several staff members from University of Galway have periodically received a very high volume of emails from Cian. This has been a recurrent feature of his problematic presentations when unwell, and one staff member reports

No	Hazard	Who is at Risk	What is the Risk/Likely Injury	Current Control/Preventative Measures in place	Current Risk Rating			Additional Controls/Actions Required.	Anticipated / Revised Risk Rating			Person Responsible	Target Date
					L	S	RR		L	S	RR		
1	CmL sending a very high volume of disturbing emails to University of Galway staff members.	Staff members	Current emotional distress requiring support from counselling.	No option to block emails from students. Supports provided to staff.	5	4	20	Suspend the student until he can provide formal evidence from his treating consultant confirming consistent engagement with the relevant mental health support services, compliance with any treatment/medication required, and certifying that he is mentally stable and well enough to re-engage with his academic studies.	3	4	12		
	CmL sending a very high volume of disturbing emails to University of Galway staff members.	Staff members	Potential to cause interruption to the staff member's ability to continue with their role.	No option to block emails from students. Supports provided to staff.	4	4	16	Suspend the student until he can provide formal evidence from his treating consultant confirming consistent engagement with the relevant mental health support services, compliance with any treatment/medication required, and certifying that he is mentally stable and well enough to re-engage with his academic studies.	2	4	8		

	CmL sending a very high volume of disturbing emails to University of Galway staff members.	Staff members	Implication for staff in relation to reporting obligations under children first in view of content and volume of emails.	Consultation with University legal team and Tusla in relation to this.	4	5	20	Suspend the student until he can provide formal evidence from his treating consultant confirming consistent engagement with the relevant mental health support services, compliance with any treatment/medication required, and certifying that he is mentally stable and well enough to re-engage with his academic studies.	2	5	10		
	CmL sending emails from his student account to a broad number of recipients, naming staff members and representing their actions in an inaccurate light.	Staff members	Reputational damage for academic/ support staff/ management.	None	5	4	20	Suspend the student until he can provide formal evidence from his treating consultant confirming consistent engagement with the relevant mental health support services, compliance with any treatment/medication required, and certifying that he is mentally stable and well enough to re-engage with his academic studies.	2	4	8		
	CmL demonstrating very poor insight in relation to the severity of his condition and his need for intervention when unwell.	CmL	Continuing to experience acute symptoms due to non compliance with treatment e.g. medication.	None	5	4	20	Clear boundaries from external sources (i.e. University enforcing suspension) may support CmL to realise the natural consequences of non engagement with services to manage mental health issues.	3	4	12		
	CmL attempting to engage with studies when experiencing mental health challenges and not engaging with medical supports.	CmL	The student demonstrates an increase of self doubt/ self condemnation when engaging academically which will place additional pressure on his mental health.	Access to services in University but unable to engage when in acute phase of being unwell.	5	4	20	Suspend the student until he can provide formal evidence from his treating consultant confirming consistent engagement with the relevant mental health support services, compliance with any treatment/medication required, and certifying that he is mentally stable and well enough to re-engage with his academic studies.	2	4	8		

[illegible]

Appendix 1: Risk Assessment Grid

Also consider other aspects which are relevant. The tick-boxes are provided for optional use to identify concerns.

1. Intentional Self-Harm	2. Unintentional Self-Harm	3. Risk From Others	4. Risk To Others	5. Survival	6. Psychological	7. Social
Individual factors: ☐ expressing suicidal intent ☐ clear plan ☐ available means ☐ preparations ☐ hopelessness ☐ no confidant, e.g. partner, friends, professionals ☐ poor coping resources ☐ lack of blocks to self-harm Consider risk factors: ☐ past history of deliberate self-harm ☒ (i) alcohol/drug abuse OR (ii) diagnosis (e.g. depression, schizophrenia, personality disorder) ☐ (i) AND (ii) = increased risk ☐ physical illness/disability ☐ recent GP contact ☒ recent psychiatric hospitalisation ☐ recent loss ☐ no friends/family ☐ living alone ☐ unskilled worker ☐ unemployment ☐ older people ☒ male (especially young males)	Consider self-neglect: ☐ lack of self-care ☐ not eating or drinking appropriately Consider unsafe behaviour: ☒ not seeking help for problems posing risk ☒ refusing appropriate help e.g. not taking medication ☐ not claiming benefits ☐ lack of awareness of own safety in home e.g. fire risk ☐ risky sexual behaviour ☐ substance misuse ☐ wandering Consider the inability to maintain a safe environment: ☐ unable to manage accommodation ☐ not paying rent ☐ running up debts	Consider different types of abuse or exploitation: ☒ physical ☐ sexual ☐ emotional ☐ racial ☐ financial ☐ neglect Consider risk from: ☒ students ☐ staff ☐ relatives ☐ friends ☐ neighbours ☒ strangers ☐ treatments Consider risk of abuse by carer: ☐ severe stress ☐ mental illness/alcohol/drug abuse in carer ☐ carer refusing help ☐ history of abuse by or to carer Consider risk from society: ☐ history of abusive/exploitative relationships ☐ harassment from public ☐ use of home by unwanted others ☐ inadequate home security ☐ fear of retaliation for reporting abuse	Consider risk to: ☐ students ☐ children & other dependents ☐ partners ☐ carers ☒ staff ☐ neighbours ☐ strangers Consider risk factors: ☐ current threats, especially to a named person ☐ history of violence to people/property ☐ carer's concern ☐ access to weapons ☐ no blocks to violence e.g. fear of consequences ☐ history of arson ☐ unemployment ☐ drug/alcohol abuse ☐ stress ☐ voices telling person to harm someone ☐ paranoia ☐ risky sexual behaviour ☐ anti-social behaviour ☐ lack of information about person's history ☐ no trusting relationship with professionals ☐ general or specific threats based upon extreme political or religious position ☒ emotional/psychological distress	Consider whether the person has problems with: ☐ a home ☐ heating for the home ☐ essential amenities (e.g. washing facilities, toilet, cooker, bed) ☐ the ability to look after their home ☐ the ability to keep adequately clean and tidy ☐ enough food & fluids ☐ clothing ☒ enough money to live on ☐ mobility ☐ the ability to use public transport ☐ the ability to cope with physical health problems	Consider: ☒ overactive, aggressive, disruptive or agitated behaviour <i>via email</i> ☐ problems with hallucinations & delusions ☐ cognitive problems with memory, orientation & understanding ☐ mood problems e.g. depressed, manic, anxious ☐ problems with reading or writing ☐ a lack of coping strategies ☒ attitude to problems ☐ help seeking behaviour ☐ spiritual problems ☐ feelings of alienation	Consider problems in relationships with others: ☐ lack of ability to make or maintain friendships ☒ lack of supportive relationships ☐ lack of intimate relationship ☐ sexual problems ☐ communication problems ☐ unable to handle daily hassles Consider problems in activities: ☒ education ☐ home/domestic ☐ leisure ☐ unpaid work ☐ paid work ☐ travel ☐ lack of personally meaningful life

Risk	☐ Mild ☒ Moderate ☐ Elevated ☐ Severe ☐ Extreme	☐ Mild ☐ Moderate ☐ Elevated ☒ Severe ☐ Extreme	☐ Mild ☒ Moderate ☐ Elevated ☐ Severe ☐ Extreme	☐ Mild ☐ Moderate ☐ Elevated ☒ Severe ☐ Extreme	☐ Mild ☐ Moderate ☒ Elevated ☐ Severe ☐ Extreme	☐ Mild ☐ Moderate ☐ Elevated ☒ Severe ☐ Extreme
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This assessment grid is based on the 'Threshold Assessment Grid (TAG)' developed by the Institute of Psychiatry at King's College London (Slade et al., Soc. Psychiatry



20 September 2024

Cian Mac Liatháin (11476078)

Dear Cian,

I am writing to inform you that the President, Professor Peter McHugh, having consulted as appropriate, is of the opinion that there are sufficiently serious grounds for concerns about your behaviour and well-being, as exhibited through your extensive and repeated emails to staff, to invoke an immediate temporary suspension under Section 9 and Appendix 5 of QA269 Support for Students in Crisis policy (please see attached).

This is a temporary measure, taken with a view to the duty of care owed to both yourself and the University community. The decision has been exercised with due regard to natural justice and fair procedure.

Please note, this temporary suspension shall not be regarded as an indication as to whether or not the grounds for concern is proven.

Next Steps

- In my capacity as Dean of Students, I will now invoke Stage 3 of QA269 Support for Students in Crisis policy, and a review panel will engage with you to determine the supports necessary.
- The time period for the suspension has not yet been determined. This will be assessed by the review panel.
- We will endeavour to move as expeditiously as possible to arrange a meeting of the review panel. We do not expect there to be a lengthy wait, but we will need to follow the steps outlined in the policy (attached).
- In line with Appendix 5, point 6 of the policy, every reasonable effort will be made to support you to continue your academic studies:
 - You may continue to engage with those aspects of your course where materials are available on Canvas, including pre-recorded lectures.
 - You shall not attend the live lectures, campus-based activities, or engage with the discussion board elements of the course.
- Throughout your suspension, you are not permitted to physically access the campus.



OLLSCOIL NA GAILLIMHE
UNIVERSITY OF GALWAY

- Throughout your suspension, all queries must be directed to deanofstudents@universityofgalway.ie only. Other emails should not be copied into the correspondence. Should this not be respected, the University will have to take measures to temporarily restrict your email access. Reasonable response times apply.
- Throughout your suspension, you retain the right to access University of Galway Student Counselling Service. Sessions can be delivered online. Should you wish to avail of this service, please email deanofstudents@universityofgalway.ie and the Office of the Dean of Students will make the arrangements.

The University will notify you of next steps in due course having regard to the requirements of the QA269 Support for Students in Crisis policy.

Regards,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Ciara Meehan'.

Professor Ciara Meehan
Dean of Students